

CHAPTER- VI

THE STATE OF NON FORMAL EDUCATION

6.1. Introduction

Non Formal Education is conceptualized as an organized educational activity, occurring in the traditional framework of formal education system. Formal education is highly structured and rigid. It is characterized by uniformity to a large extent. The major characteristic feature of NFE in India is its flexibility in terms of organization, timing and duration of teaching and learning, clientele groups, age group of learners, contents, methodology of instruction and evaluation procedure. It is this characteristic feature of NFE, which has made it a critical mode for reaching out to the hardest-to-reach group of children and youth, both in rural and urban India, in order to achieve the much desired goal of education for all.²⁸²

The right to basic education is a widely considered fundamental human right and it is an essential pre-condition for the progress of the nation. The existing formal education system has not been able to cater to the needs of the Indian population. The Constitution of India, in Article 45, mentions compulsory primary education for all children up to fourteen years of age. This has not been possible even after more than sixty years of independence. This has created the need for a new revised educational system

²⁸² Available at: www.unesco.org/education/e-9/initiative and K. Biswal, National Institute of Educational Planning and Administration, New Delhi, India; in ANTRIEP (bi-annual newsletter) Vol 6, No 2, July-December. 2001.

concentrated mainly on the rural poor who are outside the mainstream of formal education. The new system is known as Non Formal Education; it is outside the formal education programmes. It imparts continuous education to the participants irrespective of their age, sex and educational background.

6.2. Scope of Non Formal Education

India has got more than enough scope to expand its literacy and non-formal educational programs in order to transform the population into human resources through providing livelihood skill training which may be helpful to the countries to reach at the expected level of development. Non-formal and adult education considered as a human resource development and productive investment. The education of adults contributes to their self-reliance and personal autonomy, to the exercise of basic rights and to increased productivity and labour efficiency. The scope of NFE covers activities ranging from all areas of formal education including rural development, nutrition, health, family planning and agriculture.²⁸³ It enriches the learning received through formal education. It exploits the available time and interest of the individual in bringing out the inherent knowledge, so that the individual can improve his or her conditions of living.²⁸⁴ The methods followed by NFE are mainly the learner-oriented and based on dialogue between learner and educator. Non-Formal Education has certain differences from informal education. The International Council for Educational Development (ICED) has cited the following valuable distinction between Non Formal Education and informal learning:

By informal education we mean the truly, life-long process

where by every individual acquires attitudes, values, skills and

²⁸³ Mohanty, S. B. 1988: *Lifelong Adult Education*. New Delhi: Ashish Publishing House. p. 105.

²⁸⁴ Ibid.

knowledge from daily experience and the educative influences and resources in his or her environment- from family and neighbours, from work and play, from the market place, the library and the mass media. . . . We define for Non-Formal Education as any organized educational activity outside the established formal system-whether operating separately or as an important feature of some broader activity-that is intended to server identifiable learning clienteles and learning objective.²⁸⁵

6.3. Defining Literacy in the Indian Context

The National Literacy Mission (NLM), the most important state mechanism for imparting NFE, defines literacy as acquiring the skills of reading, writing and arithmetic and *the ability to apply them to one's day-to-day life*. Thus the goal of the NLM goes beyond the simple achievement of self-reliance in literacy. The achievement of functional literacy implies:

Self-reliance in the 3 Rs.

Becoming aware of the causes of deprivation and moving towards amelioration of their condition by participating in the process of development. Acquiring skills to improve their economics status and general well-being. Imbibing values of national integration, conservation of environment, women's equality, and observance of small family norms. The acquisition of functional literacy results in empowerment and a definite improvement in the quality of life. It helps to ensure the

²⁸⁵ Qtd. from Torsten and T. Neville Postlethwaite. 1985: *The International Encyclopaedia of Education, Research and Studies*. New York: Pergamon Press. p. 3557.

participation of the masses in sharing the benefits of the information era.²⁸⁶

Poverty and equity comprise major distinctive elements of the conceptualization.

The 3 Rs have been characterized in the NLM thus:

Reading

Reading aloud, with normal accent, and at a speed of 30 words a minute, a simple passage on a topic of interest to the learner.

Silent reading at 35 words a minute, of small paragraphs in simple language.

Reading with understanding the road signs, posters, simple instructions and newspapers/ broadsheets designed for neo-literates.

Ability to follow simple written passages relating to one's working and living environment

Writing

Copying, with understanding, 7 words a minute.

Taking dictation at 5 words a minute.

Writing with proper spacing and alignment.

Writing independently, short letters and applications, and filling in forms of day-to-day use to the learner.

Numeracy

Reading and writing numerals 1-100.

²⁸⁶ <http://www.nlm.nic.in>

Doing simple calculations (without fraction) involving addition and subtraction up to 3 digits, and multiplication and division by 2 digits.

Working knowledge of metric units weights, measures currency, distance, area and unit of time. Broad idea of proportion and interests (not involving fractions) and their use inpractical situations.²⁸⁷

6.4. Defining non formal education

Defining non formal education is very difficult. The definition offered by Coombs, Prosser and Ahmed (1973), which assigns NFE its place in the educational universe, has become a classic. Carron and Carr-Hill (1991:5-6) summarize the distinctions they offer as follows²⁸⁸

... *formal education* ... (is) the institutionalized, chronologically graded and hierarchically structured education system, running from lower primary school to the upper reaches of the university, generally full time and sanctioned by the state; *non-formal education* ... (comprises) all educational activities organized outside the formal system and designed to serve identifiable clientele and educational objectives ... with all remaining educational activities being categorized as *informal education* ... (is) the lifelong process by which

²⁸⁷ <http://www.nlm.nic.in>

²⁸⁸ Carron, G and Carr-Hill, R A. 1991: Non-formal education: information and planning issues. International Institute for Educational Planning, Paris. pp. 5-6. Cited from Spronk, Barbara. 'Non Formal Education at a Distance: A Framework for Discussion.' www.col.org/forum/pcfpapers/spronk.pdf.

every person acquires and accumulates knowledge, skills, attitudes
and insights from daily experience and exposure to the environment...

Non formal education, then, occupies the middle ground between the traditional school system and informal learning practices, with no particularly clear or sharp edges at the boundaries. For example, forms of schooling for children that happen not to take place within classroom walls, yet which teach the formal curriculum in somewhat more flexible fashion and which potentially feed into the formal examinations and credentialing system, are often lumped in with the informal system. These, however, are perhaps more usefully termed according to Spronk “alternative” schools within the formal system.²⁸⁹

According to Spronk, at the other end of this “formal-non formal-in formal” continuum, non formal initiatives often appear to be so “informal” compared with the rigours of the formal system that they tend to merge with the informal sector.²⁹⁰

She identifies three main points from the Coombs et al. definition, which are helpful, in terms of setting NFE off from the informal sector. First, non formal education is organized. That is, it is planned, designed, structured and managed; it does not happen casually. Second, NFE serves “identifiable clientele”. In other words, NFE offers opportunities for learning to clearly identified target audiences. And third, NFE also has clearly defined educational objectives. Although it is outside the formal system, NFE shares these characteristics with formal education, and this helps to distinguish it from informal education.

Rogers²⁹¹ offers the following comparison between formal and non formal education:

²⁸⁹ Spronk, Barbara. ‘Non Formal Education at a Distance: A Framework for Discussion.’ Available at www.col.org/forum/pcfpapers/spronk.pdf.

²⁹⁰ Ibid.

	Formal Education	Non Formal Education
Target group	mainly young universal compulsory selective	mainly adults those interested voluntary open
Time Scale	full time primary activity of participants	part time secondary activity of participants
Relevance	separate from life in special institutions in sole purpose buildings	integrated with life in the community in all kinds of settings
Programme	run by professionals excludes large parts of life	participatory excludes nothing
Curriculum	one kind of education for all set curriculum compartmentalized	education to meet learner defined needs open curriculum

²⁹¹ Rogers, A (1996) "NFE, development and learning", Unit 2 of Course 7, *Non formal and adult basic education at a distance*, in University of London/IEC External Diploma/MA in Distance Education. University of London/IEC, Cambridge. p. 33. Available at www.col.org/forum/pcfpapers/spronk.pdf.

	subject centered	integrated
	controlled by teacher	problem- centered
		controlled by learners
Methods	teacher- centered	learner- centered
	mainly written	much is oral
Objectives	conformist	promotes independence
	set by teachers	set by learners
	competitive	collaborative
	individualist	collective
Orientation	future	present
Relationships	hierarchical	egalitarian
Validation	terminal at each stage	continuing
	validated by education	validated by learners
	profession	

6.5. The Concept of Non-Formal Education

Non-Formal Education covers all the important educational objectives of imparting knowledge and skills. The history of NFE in India shows that Non-Formal Education was used in the early Vedic period without using the name. The present nomenclature and concept came to India in early seventies when at the UNESCO-sponsored seminar; the out-of-school education was stressed as a strategy of ever-eluding objective of Universal

Elementary Education.²⁹² More than forty years after the seminar, it bears wider meaning and its area spread from the least extreme of literacy to the last stage of media education.

The standard definition of NFE developed in 1973 by P. H. Coombs and A. Ahmed is "any organized activities outside the established formal system-whether operating separately or an important feature of some broader activity-that is intended to serve identifiable learning clienteles and learning objectives."²⁹³ Then later a number of Indian as well as foreign educationists defined the term with necessary alterations. In 1974 the report of Ministry of Education, India, clarifies that:

Non-Formal Education is meant to cover various educational needs of non-school going children or 'drop-outs', these programmes are supposed to be differentiated based on conditions prevailing in various environments, oriented to help children to improve their work, earnings, health, family life, understanding of the natural and social surroundings etc.²⁹⁴

The document of UNESCO Regional Office at Bangkok (1978) mentions the following general objectives of Non-Formal Education programmes: (a) to promote awareness through pre-literacy education and acceptance of learning as a means to individual and national development; (b) to provide equal educational opportunities for all, and through them mere equitable distributions of gains and employment avenues; (c) to establish national infrastructural needs and provide manpower; (d) to make communities self-reliant through Improved management skills involving them

²⁹² Khanna, C. P. 1992: *Panorama of Education: A Global Perspective*. New Delhi: Doaba House. p. 145.

²⁹³ Coombs, P. H. et al. 1974: *Affecting Rural Poverty: How Non-Formal Education can Help*. Baltimore, Maryland: University Press. p. 10.

²⁹⁴ Govt. of India. 1974: *Report of Non-Formal Education*. New Delhi: Ministry of Education. p. 1.

in planning, organization and implementation of the programmes; (e) to effect transfer of technology to more need-based area of activity; (f) to mobilize existing local resources in the community; (g) to promote programmes for Non-Formal Education directly linked to productive skill and tangible gains.²⁹⁵

The concept of NFE was developed in relation to less developed countries. The villages in India suffer from inadequate education facilities and so the rural masses are systematically discriminated with the benefit of development. Indian educationists and economists think about the practicability of it. According to Malcom S. Adisheshaiah, the NFE is wide ranging because it comprehends all learning outside the formal system, and has no parameters of time and space. It can be classified for pre-school, non-school and under- school children in the age group 1-15, and for youth and adults, unschooled under- schooled needing new additional skills in the age group 15-60. Non-formal learning can be classified by the learning content involved into these organized activities where the major emphasis is on general education, and also those where the content is mainly vocational.²⁹⁶

According to Aravind Chandra et al., "education is imparted in a free atmosphere, without the rigidity of rules and regulations associated with school or college education, it is termed as Non-Formal Education."²⁹⁷ The academic objectives of NFE are clustered around dropouts from formal education, functional illiterates, unemployed and underemployed youths and adults.²⁹⁸ There are a number of educational activities and

²⁹⁵ Mohanty, S. B. *op. cit.*, p. 108.

²⁹⁶ Singh, R. P. 1987: *Non-Formal Education: An Alternative Approach*. New Delhi: Sterling Publishers. p.2.

²⁹⁷ Chandra, Aravind and Anupam Shah. 1987: *Non-Formal Education for All* New Delhi: Sterling Publishers. p. 1.

²⁹⁸ Ibid. p. 8.

programme that can be termed as NFE including literacy, adult education, distance education, open university, extension activities, including those of agriculture, health, population education etc. Thus the process of education provided to the child or adults or any group, which is structured but outside the formal education is normally called Non-Formal Education. As for the objectives of Non-Formal Education, Dr. Shirur says, "the objectives of Non-Formal Education are to provide basic knowledge and skills, practice and attitudes necessary for each group to become conscious of their needs and problems and to learn to achieve their individual and social goals."²⁹⁹ The above descriptions prove that Non-Formal Education has become a medium for social change as the knowledge and skills needed urgently. Thus the process of education provided to the child or adults or any group, which is structured but outside the formal education is normally called Non-Formal Education.

6.6. Non-Formal Education and Rural Development

Development means the uplift of human beings with reference to their socio-economic life. In this, education plays a vital role. A large section of our population is not able to respond to formal education because of a number of socio-economic problems. But in the case of rural areas, the problem is acute. In this situation the importance of NFE programmes cannot be overestimated. Formal educational institutions are mainly concentrated in urban areas. Formal education still remains beyond the reach of most of the people in rural areas. Non-Formal Education is the answer to rural illiteracy and ignorance. The report of Ministry of Education "the fifth five-year plan educational strategies is also based on the assumption that non-formal ways of imparting and requiring education will be developed for all categories of learners and an all Levels of

²⁹⁹ Shirur. 1977: Indian Journal of Adult Education, Vol. 38. p. 3.

education for children, youth and adults from elementary to higher education.³⁰⁰ Rural development does not start with goods and commodities; it starts with people's needs and desires. It can be achieved through education.

Non-Formal Education can meet many aspects of rural development. It is necessary to establish interrelationship between occupation and NFE through training of village industries, handicrafts, self-employment etc. Students of professional institutions, polytechnics and universities can play a very effective role in imparting skills to rural people. This kind of help link their degrees and encourage them to take up voluntary activities. Functional education programmes can be divided into three types:³⁰¹

(a) literacy programmes for non-school going children in the age group of 6 to 14 years; (b) vocational education, family welfare education and literacy programme for youth in the age group of 15 to 25 years; (c) functional literacy for job improvement and self-employment programmes for adults in the age group of 26 years and above. The teachers and the persons responsible for the execution of the NFE programmes call change agents.³⁰² Non-Formal Education for rural development has been incorporated in many schemes, projects and plans for the uplift of the rural masses. Rural universities on the line of Mahatma Gandhi's revolutionary ideas on education can lead to the transformation of rural areas.

6.7. NFE in the Context of Education Commissions and National Policies

Education is a powerful instrument of national development. So the reforms to the transformation and improvement in each age had taken by government at every time. The

³⁰⁰ Report of NFE op. cit., p. 5.

³⁰¹ Aravind Chandra, *op. cit.*, p. 155.

³⁰² *Ibid.* p. 161.

national leaders realized that a revolutionary approach is needed to bring radical changes in objectives, structures, process and organization of education. Before independence the policy of education in India was not national in character as the country was under foreign rule and the educational policy objectives aimed at fulfilling the purpose of a colonial government. A major portion of Indian population is illiterate. It is only by spreading the facilities of education; India can emerge as a new and stronger nation. This can happen only when illiteracy is wiped out completely from our country. A huge portion of our population between the age group of 5-35 years is not able to receive formal education and does not get the benefit of regular education. Therefore, the system of Non-Formal Education should be utilized to deal with this growing problem. Various education commissions and national policies stressed the system of education outside the formal structure of education.

Recommendations for NFE in Kothari Commission, 1964-66

The Education Commission of 1964-66 set up by the Government of India, and popularly known as Kothari Commission recommended NFE on a large scale for out of school children and adults. The Commission put stress more on literacy, continuing education, correspondence courses etc. All these linked with adult education programmes. The Commission present that India was more illiterate in 1961 than 1951, so as massive unorthodox national effort is necessary. All economic and social developmental plans have their human aspect and involve a large number of persons who have had no schooling. It is therefore, logical that every developmental project in whatever field should include an integral part and plan for the education of its

employees, more especially of those who are illiterate.³⁰³ The Commission also recommended correspondence courses for those who are unable to attend regular courses. There must also be a method of taking education to the million who depend upon their own efforts to study whenever they can find time to do so.³⁰⁴ Correspondence courses or home study provides the right answer for this situation. Lessons should be broadcast through the media of radio, T. V. and magazines. The Commission recommended fullest exploitation of mass media of communication and which effectively used as a powerful instrument for creating the climate and impart knowledge and skills necessary for improving the quality of work and standard of life of the people. The Kothari Commission has recommended the setting up of libraries all over the country and the use of school libraries for the public benefit. Libraries play a crucial role in imparting knowledge and awareness. Universities can make a valuable contribution to the proper development of Non-Formal Education. The Commission also recommended that each university should have a department of Adult and Continuing Education.

The National Policy on Education, 1968

On the basis of Kothari Commission's Report, National Education Commission was set up for reviewing the structure and evolves a national education policy. Liquidation of mass illiteracy is an essential component for accelerating programme of production and quickening the tempo of national development. With a view to reducing the number of illiterates part-time literacy classes should be organized for grown up children. All employees in large commercial, industrial and other concerns should be made functionally literate within a prescribed period of their employment and a lead in this

³⁰³ Govt. of India. 1974: *Report of Education Commission 1964-66* New Delhi: Ministry of Education. p. 434.

³⁰⁴ *Ibid.*, p. 435.

direction should be given by the industrial plant in public sector.³⁰⁵ Similarly, teachers, students and educational institutions should be actively involved in literacy campaigns. The achievement of literacy should be sustained by the provision of attractive reading materials and library service to new literates. Part-time and own-time education is another important component of national policy for NFE. These facilities will smoothen the transition from school to work, reduce the cost of education to the state, and provide opportunities for desired people. In particular greater emphasis has to be laid on the development of correspondence courses, not only for university students, but also for secondary school students, for teachers, for agricultural, industrial and other workers; and facilities should be available to both men and women, to study privately and appear at the various examinations conducted by the boards of examination and the universities.³⁰⁶

National Education Policy 1979

There were ten years after National Education Policy 1968, education at all levels needs to a functional revision in relation to the felt needs and potentialities of the of the people. Emphasis should be shift from teaching to learning, the role of learner being more crucial. The policy highlights Gandhiji's ideas and experiments in the field of education, i.e. correlation of hand and heart leading to complementarity of intellectual and manual work is important and useful to society, community service and participation in constructive and socially useful productive work should be an integral part of education at all stages so as to foster self-reliance and the dignity of labor. It stress the need of Non-Formal Education while it is necessary to expand the facilities for formal education in

³⁰⁵ Rasool, G. 1968: *National Policy on Education*. New Delhi: Ministry of Education, Govt. of India. p. 59.

³⁰⁶ Ibid., p. 56.

elementary schools for all children in the age group 6-14, it is also important to formulate schemes of Non-Formal Education for dropouts and the older children in the age group who have not had any schooling.³⁰⁷ Adult education and literacy programme came under preview of Non-Formal Education. At that time illiterate adult population was 230 million. Planners think that their contribution to national development could be increased, if they received same education. The nation should deem its solemn duty to impart education to them. The concept of adult education defined that not the acquisition of literacy and numeracy and also functional development and social awareness with a view to cultivating the habit of self-education.³⁰⁸ It also includes the part of Revised Minimum Need Programme whose thrust is to reach the poor people. Since the real problem of adult illiteracy exists in the rural areas, special efforts will have to be made to involve the rural community and teachers in the rural areas to conduct this programme. A special effort should be made to advice *mahila mandals* and youth organizations. Some input from the community would be desirable to make it a continuing programme. Besides removing illiteracy and creating awareness, adult education programme has to have some developmental content. It should also aim at improving the skills of the target groups so that their productivity can be improved.³⁰⁹ The policy viewed certain measures for the continuation of adult education including low-price books and literature, village libraries etc. The development of rural library system is necessary to support the programme of continuing education.

Recommendations for NFE in New National Policy of Education, 1986

³⁰⁷ *National Policy on Education 1979* (Article 4) Available at www.ncert.nic.in/oth_anoun/npe86.pdf

³⁰⁸ *Ibid.*, Article 3.1

³⁰⁹ *Ibid.*, Article 3.7.

The directive principles of Indian Constitution provide the provision of free and compulsory education to all children up to the fourteen years old. Between the period of 1951 to New National Policy of Education, 1986, a number of institutions started for elementary education. But which is not fully effective to attain the real goal. The national policies of 1968 and 1979 give much emphasis on elementary education and adult education. The Education Commission 1966 has rightly stated: "Education does not end with schooling, but it is a life-long process."³¹⁰

In 1985, the newly elected Prime Minister addressed the nation to propose a new and dynamic educational policy for India. National Policy in 1986 gives greater emphasis on NFE. A large and systematic programme of Non-Formal Education will be launched for school drop-outs, for children from habitations without schools, working children and girls of whole day schools.³¹¹ Effective steps will be taken to provide a framework for the curriculum, but based on the needs of the learners and related to the local environment.³¹² The Fifth Five Year Plan's educational strategy is also based on the assumption that non-formal ways of imparting and acquiring education will be developed for all categories of learners and on all levels of education for children, youth and adults from elementary to higher education.³¹³ Centrally assisted schemes introduced for running NFE centres in the ten educational backward states, viz. Uttar Pradesh, Jammu Kashmir, Rajasthan. Madhya Pradesh, Andhra Pradesh, Bihar, W. Bengal, Orissa, Arunachal Pradesh and Assam. The aim of the policy assures all children up to fourteen years provide free and compulsory education before 1995.

³¹⁰ Report of Education Commission 1964-66, p. 423.

³¹¹ *National Policy on Education 1986*, p. 11.

³¹² *Ibid.*, p. 12.

³¹³ *Reprot of Non-Formal Education*, op. cit., p. 1.

6.8. Teaching Methods and Learning Material for NFE

Learners of Non-Formal Education differ from the learners of the formal education. So the methods used for NFE must suite to the background of non-formal learners. The teacher-oriented methods such as formal class lectures will not work effectively in NFE. The methods ensuring maximum learner participation of the learners is applicable in this field. Methods such as talks cum demonstration, workshop, group discussion, self-study and contact classes are the most appropriate methods for NFE. Methods that permit interaction, involvement and opportunities to express one self should be choose for non-formal teaching. A combination of two or more methods will be effective for larger groups and individuals who seek varying objectives from NFE.

An oral explanation becomes easier to understand through a demonstration so it considered more appealing and effective method. A good and proper demonstration requires systematic planning regarding all details. The workshop method is more effective than a demonstration, as the learner get personally involved in learning by doing.³¹⁴ Unlike the demonstration method in which the learners are usually passive observers, in a workshop, the learners themselves, in groups, prepare the article or articles under the guidance of the instructor. Group discussion is another fruitful method in the field of NFE. In a group discussion members expose their views and arrived at a mutually agreed solution. Materials used in NFE are easily grasped by learners. The five senses sight, hearing, touch, smell and taste-make understanding of concrete and material things possible. The audio-visual aids make the learning process clear, simpler and interesting. Audio-visual aids have a special significance for the learners who come from

³¹⁴ Chandra, Aravind. *op. cif.*, p. 4.

different backgrounds, and have various abilities and experiences. These materials help the learners to build common platform of experience and to proceed from there to the abstract of non-material aspect of learning.³¹⁵ Graphic aids include chart, diagrams, flashcards, pictures and photographs and these are mostly used to present information through eye-catching writings and illustrations. Displays on chalkboards, bulletin boards and flannel boards used for presenting information.

Three-dimensional aids-objects, specimen and models are more useful in Non-Formal Education. Objects are real things which help in developing correct concept and understanding of things. Specimen is art of actual objects or a group of similar objects. Models differ from the real things in size and material; it may either be smaller or bigger than the original. Projected aids like slides, filmstrips, television and videotapes commonly used in Non-Formal Education. Leaflets, folders, brochures etc. is very much useful to neo-literates. Graphical materials, displays and projected aids will have to be used according to the age, ability and experience of the learners.

6.9. Evaluation Scheme of NFE

Formal education has organized evaluation schemes, elaborate theories and rigid practical tests, with a stringent system of final examination to evaluate the students for success or failure. But all this methods are absent in Non-Formal Education. It follows different criteria for evaluation, confined not judging the performance of the individual beneficiary, but to evaluate what NFE has done for the educational and intellectual awareness of the community. It is necessary to find, whether there has been any positive

³¹⁵ Ibid., p. 81.

impact on learners. Evaluation is also needed to make better plans for the future. Periodical evaluation can help to find the weakness and deficiencies in planning and implementation, so that corrective steps can be taken in this time. There are six methods used for evaluation in NFE. They are attendance, cost effectiveness, use of knowledge and abilities acquired, budget utilization, reaction of the learners and reaction of the instructor.³¹⁶

Overall attendance of the learners is a significant indication of the **keenness** of the learners. Attendance can be according to the programmes. Cost effectiveness of the project in terms of input-out ratio can be worked out to evaluate the programme. The records of the income and the expenditure can be checked to find out if the resources are being properly utilized for the intended purpose and there is no wastage or leakage. The reaction of learners can be measured through questionnaires and check-lists which can be administered in groups or individually, separately for the illiterates and literates, and the less educated persons. The reaction of the instructor can be in the form of a report on his satisfaction regarding impact of the Non-Formal Education on learners. University level NFE programme has been properly evaluated by examinations and assessments.

The most difficult aspect of Non-Formal Education is its correct evaluation as evaluation refers to a formal component.

6.10. NFE Programmes³¹⁷

Total Literacy Campaign (TLC)

³¹⁶ Ibid.

³¹⁷ Mitra. Amit. 2008: 'Education for All Global Monitoring Report 2008 Education for All by 2015: will we make it?' EFA Global Monitoring Report: UNESCO.

One of the major government initiatives, *the Total Literacy Campaign (TLC)* run by the National Literacy Mission (NLM), was started in 1988-89, initially as an experiment. It was area specific, time bound, volunteer based, outcome oriented and had a mass programme character. The core activities of the programme were literacy and numeracy. The targeted age group was illiterates in the age of 15 to 35. After the campaign was over, the neo-literates moved on to Post-literacy Programmes (PLP) and Continuing Education (CE). The minimum duration of the TLC was 6 months with PLP and CE was 3 months. The programme was imparted in the vernacular and the trainers were local volunteers. In the initial phases, literacy was the only competency focused on.

However, In the light of EFA goals and targets set up in the Dakar Framework for Action and clearly aligned to social and gender equity thrusts, the NLM, under the aegis of MHRD in 2003, felt the necessity to effect a certain re-focusing of its strategies pursued since 1999. The EFA-NPA's (National Plan of Action) new "thrust areas" in literacy include achievement of 75 percent literacy level by 2007, a multi-pronged strategy to address regional, social and gender disparities in literacy, refocusing literacy, post-literacy and CE programmes to increase and strengthen women's participation, to bridge gender gap in literacy, encouraging PL and CE districts to pay special attention on mobilization and organization of women into neo-literate and self-help groups (SHGs), special attention to socially disadvantaged groups like Schedule Castes / Scheduled Tribes and women.

Sarva Siksha Abhiyan (SSA)

Another government-run programme for UEE, with a view to Alternative Schooling and alternative education to a section of drop-outs, is the *Sarva Siksha Abhiyan (SSA)*, started

in 2001. The important features of SSA are Education Guarantee Scheme (EGS) and Alternative and Innovative Education (AIE) that seeks to base itself on strong community involvement and micro planning exercises. The EGS & AIE generally cover children in the age group of 6-14 years; however, for children with disabilities, it covers children up to the age of 18 years, complying with the provisions of Persons with Disabilities (Equal Opportunities, Protection or Rights and full Participation) Act, 1995.

The SSA has laid down various strategies for adolescent girls too. They are similar to interventions adopted under the Mahila Samakhyas programme and several other NGO run programmes in different states. These include Jagjagi centers, short duration motivational and literacy centers which are residential in nature, from where the girls could go on to attend longer duration residential camps. The focus of these motivational/preparatory centers, apart from inducting the girls into the formal system is also impart life oriented and gender sensitive education. The learners apart from reading and writing get information regarding legal aid, health care, environment and women issues. The SSA also offers bridge Courses, remedial courses, Back-to-School Camps with a focus on mainstreaming out of school children into regular schools.

Jan Shikshan Sansthan (JSS)

Originally known as the Shramik Vidyapeeth, was first established in the country in Worli, Mumbai in 1967. JSS or the Institute of People's Education was initially launched as a polyvalent or multi-faceted adult education programme aimed at improving the vocational skill and quality of life of workers and their family members. The programme was evolved to respond to the educational and vocational training needs of numerous groups of adult and young people living in urban and industrial areas and for persons who

had been migrating from rural to urban settings. Now with the emergence of millions of neo-literates through the total literacy campaigns and the transformation that has taken place in the economic and social set up over the years, the role and scope of these polyvalent educational institutes have widened manifold.

In the changed scenario, the focus of JSS is now shifting from industrial workers in urban areas to the numerous neo-literates and un-skilled and unemployed youth throughout the country. The Sansthans act as district level resource support agencies especially in regard to organization of vocational training and skill development programmes for the neo-literates and other target groups of the continuing education scheme. Originally the JSS scheme was restricted to urban, semi-urban and industrial areas. Now, the area of operation has been extended to the entire districts including rural areas. As per the revised guidelines issued by the Government of India, at least 25 percent of the beneficiaries of the Jan Shikshan Sansthan should be neo-literates.

The JSSs offer around 255 different types of vocational courses - from candle and agarbatti making, sewing and embroidery to computer courses.

Earlier, the JSSs were set up under the aegis of non-government organizations, State Governments and Universities. On the other hand, JSS Delhi is directly under the Government of India. However, as per the revised guidelines issued by the Government of India, the Jan Shikshan Sansthans will function only under the NGOs. Efforts are on way to transfer all the Jan Shikshan Sansthans to run under the aegis of the State Governments to the NGO sector.

In the year 2004-5, there were 157 institutions with the training capacity of 0.35 million, with 0.15 million trained so far.

National Institute of Open Schooling (NIOS)

Established in 1989 as National Open School (NOS) by MHRD, Government of India, the *National Institute of Open Schooling (NIOS)* was renamed in July 2002 and is the largest Open Schooling System in the World Providing Alternative Schooling System.

The NIOS has 1805 academic study centres and 917 Vocational study centres throughout the country with 249 Centres for Open Basic Education. The enrolment for the last 5 years has been 1.4 million students.

The NIOS offers open vocational education, package courses, six months and one year vocational courses, life enrichment courses, stand-alone vocational subjects, as well as vocational subjects in combination with academic subjects.

The government of India runs various NFE schemes for adults in the realm of income generation. There are about 17 governmental departments and ministries offering training in various areas. Some of the schemes are:

DWCRA:

Introduced in 1982-83, as a sub-scheme of the Integrated Rural Development programme, DWCRA aims at developing income-generating skills and promoting activities among poor women in rural areas, subsequently improving their social and economic status. The basic unit under this scheme is a group of 10-15 poor women (though the size may be smaller in different areas).

The programme is implemented by the District Rural Development Agencies. Any economic activity suited to groups of women in line with their skills, aptitudes and local conditions can be taken up under the scheme. NGOs are also involved in the implementation of the programme and are supported by the Council for Advancement of

People's Action and Rural Technology (CAPART), an organization set up under the Ministry of Rural Areas and Employment to coordinate the development work of voluntary agencies in India. However, due to poor backward and forward linkages, lack of spontaneous financial support and selection of non-viable activities, several groups of beneficiaries are no longer supported.

TRYSEM: Established in 1979, the Training of Rural Youth for Self-Employment is aimed at developing technical and entrepreneurial skills among rural youth from families below the poverty line aged from 18 to 35 years, to enable them to take up income-generating activities. Training given under this scheme is based on the needs of the area, and is provided at such training centres as the ITIs, community polytechnics, extension training centres, Krishi Vigyan Kendras, khadi and village industry boards, state institutes of rural development or institutions run by voluntary agencies. Training under this scheme is normally for six months, during which the trainees receive a stipend. Besides, financial assistance is also provided to the training institutions and master craftsmen. However the TRYSEM has a weak link with the overall strategy of self-employment. The training is generally not related to the capacity or aptitudes of the trainees and unrelated to the demand for a particular skill.

Prime Minister's Rozgar Yojana: Launched in October 1993, the Prime Minister's Rozgar Yojana (PMRY) aims at providing wage employment and self-employment to educated unemployed youths aged between 18 and 35. The scheme envisages compulsory training for entrepreneurs for a period of 15 to 20 working days for the industrial sector after a loan is approved. The scheme is targeted to provide assistance to 220,000 educated youths during the year 1999-2000. An evaluation of this programme (IAMR, 2000)

revealed that it generates employment for about 2.4 persons per unit. The employment generation potential is found to be more in the case of industrial units (3.5 persons) than in the service (2.2 persons) and trade (1.9 persons) sectors. Training has been useful for an overwhelming majority of the beneficiaries (81 per cent). Many more youth seek assistance under the PMRY. However, almost half of the total applications are rejected by the taskforce committees of the District Industry Centres (DICs). The most important reason behind these rejections is inadequate technical skills. Therefore, the need for more training facilities is being increasingly felt by the youth before setting out on their ventures. Also there is a lack of publicity campaigns on the various aspects of PMRY like eligibility, fund availability, skills required and markets. As a result, there is little awareness among the youth about the scheme.

Apart from the schemes mentioned above, there are various other schemes which offer informal apprenticeship as well as on-the-job training by various ministries. They are: Vocational Training in Krishi Vigyan Kendras – Farm Science Centre.

Vocational Training in Khadi and Village Industries

Swarn Jayanti Gram Swarajgar Yojna

Stree Shakti

Swarn Jayanti Sahari Rojgar Yojna

Testing and certification of skills of workers engaged in the Informal sector (DGET) and many more.

Information on these schemes and programmes are hard to come by as there is no comprehensive/systematic documentation centrally available. Apart from the purely government set up and run NFE schemes, there are some initiatives run by the NGOs.

Foremost among them is the BGVS. The impetus to initiate a mass action for renewal was propelled from such an understanding. A voluntary agency, **Bharat Gyan Vigyan Samiti (BGVS)** was formed to initiate a mass action for renewal, out of many voluntary groups working under the loose umbrella of the 'People's Science Network' (PSN). BGVS considers literacy as a possible starting point for social transformation, and a means for a crusade against conditions that maintain illiteracy, a crusade against communalism, a crusade against dependence and oppression. The central slogan of BGVS has been "science and literacy for national integration and self-reliance". Through this, it seeks to capture the "emotional" support of the people. The BGVS's involvement with the TLCs, which took off in various districts, was varied. Its role ranged from motivation to project formulation and initiation, actively and in a participatory fashion, depending on the requirements of the particular situation. Looking at how a broad democratic movement, with the participation of the state machinery, can reach out to millions of people and overcome traditional hurdles, BGVS, in collaboration with various PSN groups, has been exploring further areas of development and possibilities for intervention. It is intervening in areas such as universalisation of elementary education, science popularisation, participatory watershed development programmes, rural enterprise programmes, library and cultural movements, health, environment protection and sustainable models of development.³¹⁸

Open Universities and Distance Education: A New Approach of NFE

³¹⁸ Bharat Gyan Vigyan Samithi Perspectives, Achievements, Tasks.... & Dreams. New Delhi: Bharath Gyan Vigyan Samithi.

Open University system first started in the United Kingdom with considerable success.³¹⁹ In India, Andhra Pradesh became the pioneer in establishing the university by an Act of State Legislation. This was followed by Indira Gandhi National Open University (IGNOU) in 1985 by an Act of Parliament. The establishment of the Open University got its approval from the National Policy on Education 1986. The main objective is to advance and disseminate learning by a diversity of means including the conventional and latest communication technology to large segment of population. The National Open University has to encourage other open universities and distance education system. It also provide higher education to disadvantaged groups such as those living in remote and rural areas including working people, housewives and other adults who wish to upgrade or acquire knowledge through studies in various field. It provides an innovative system which is flexible and open. It promotes national integration and the integrated development of the human personality through its policies and programmes. It means that non-formal channels of education will establish itself as a parallel system of higher education with the introduction of open universities. The Open University systems are getting state recognition and state funds and they are the most favoured institutes. Course material is specially prepared to suit self-study. IGNOU course design is slightly different. For any undergraduate there are preparatory non-credit courses for four months followed by three of study. Each course carries four credits. These courses are for students who are from non-formal channels. Open universities have study centers to contact the student and the coordinators help the students. IGNOU has regional centers in several states apart from having study centers to provide a rapport between students and

³¹⁹ International Encyclopaedia in Education, op. cit., p. 3668.

institutes-and provide facilities for contact programmes and practical training. Generally the student centers are situated in already existing polytechnics, junior colleges, universities and other institutions where an infrastructure already exists. The teachers working there are appointed as part-time tutors.

The concept of distance education has emerged as a result of man's search for an education which could be provided to a person at home. Now continuing education became the part of educational system. Most quoted definition is by Borje Holmberg, according to him, "distance education is the various forms of study at all levels which are not under the continuous, immediate supervision of tutors present with their students in lecture rooms or on the same premises, but which nevertheless, benefit from planning, guidance and tuition of a tutorial organization."³²⁰ This system of open education is well-developed in developed countries of the world. In developing countries like India, instruction through correspondence became popular. The main objective of distance education is to increase the knowledge of the educated citizens, to provide higher education to those who fail to join the regular university courses, and to ensure lesser expense and higher efficiency than the formal system of education.³²¹

The first and widely used form of distance education is correspondence courses, which also the channel of Non-Formal Education available at university level. The objective of correspondence education is to provide a new stream of education to enable a large number of persons, with necessary aptitude to acquire further knowledge to improve their personal competence. It intended to cater students who had to discontinue formal education, in geographically remote area. Courses of study for undergraduate courses

³²⁰ Garruon, D. R. 1989: *Understanding Distance Education: A Framework for the Future*. London: Routledge. p. 3.

³²¹ Hommadia, A. H. 1990: *Open University*. New Delhi: Indian Bibliographies Bureau. p. 46.

broken up into a number of modules, which are posted to students who work on the material sent to him and can obtain further guidance and clarification through writing back to the diffusing centre and through attending the periodic contact classes which are organized at or near his place of residence along with other students participating in correspondence courses.³²²

Second form of distance education is one which used not only the posted material, as in the above cases, but also the electronic media. In the use of radio and T. V. either as a supplement to postal teaching or as a comprehensive self contained form of distance education. This has rich possibilities including certain negative aspects. A third form of distance is one which breaks away from established syllabus and contents of schools and universities and innovates with new learning content. This new content may relate age and stage of learning. For instance research in any of the university adult education department has shown that illiterate adults can reach the literacy level of third or fourth standard or primary school or similar learning of a worker in a factory can combine academic study and professional training in a certain period, during which he is continuously assessed and given a certificate to proficiency which may enable him to higher position. Indira Gandhi National Open University is supposed to be the beacon of distance learning. It will also guide the states to seek to encourage distance learning in setting up similar universities. Distance method can successfully be used for catering to groups who, for geographical, economic or social reasons are unable or unwilling to make use of traditional provisions.

³²² Borah Swapna. 1990: *Distance Education*. New Delhi: Amar Prakashan. p. 37.

6.11. Need for Non-Formal Education

Education is the most powerful weapon for fighting ignorance and illiteracy and to bring about a lasting social change, for a country's progress is measured by its level of education. The universal right to education, which is basic to the quality of life is denied to these underprivileged classes. The children of poor prematurely forced to do work. Due to lack of pre-school education affect their physical and mental development. The degree of failures in the lower socio-economic class is very high in primary to higher education. Literacy and out of school training programmes strengthen their socio-economic and material upliftment. The process of urbanization also had many problems. Poor people migrated from rural areas to seek better opportunities creates tremendous problems of housing, employment, schooling etc. This widespread problem does not removed through formal developmental schemes. Every society needs educated people who should be directly involved in its democratic life. The socio-economic and cultural conditions of weaker sections of the society make it imperative that they should be helped to acquire new knowledge, skills, values and attitudes not only for their own betterment but for the good of the country as a whole. Our county therefore needs to encourage all efforts to educate the less-favored sections of the population specially where the poor and illiterate form the majority. The rigid formal education system is not reach all the sections of a society and all the categories of men and women. Only the privileged groups, by and large, avail themselves of educational facilities through schools, college, universities and technological institutions. The fixed point of entry and exist of formal education makes it more difficult for students from the weaker sections of the society re-enter it. Because of

certain causes the formal system became less suitable for the deprived sections of the society. Much more emphasis will have to be placed on the non-formal ways of education particularly for those who are excluded from the benefit of formal schooling. The importance of Non-Formal Education has also been recognized by the Government of India and it now forms an essential part of the revised educational planning. Education is now recognized as a life long process. This is applicable from illiterates to formally educated. The formally educated can continue their education and knowledge in the areas associated with their studies and work, or they can take up new subjects to study for their personal enlightenment. The formally educated can conveniently adopt non-formal programmes like correspondence courses, in service training, additional job training etc. Education in any form needs to provide improvement of their quality of life and to help them to participate productively in the national development. The formal education system, because of its rigidity excludes the poor for the advantages. The NFE, which is flexible and relevant to the lives of illiterates and poor, needs to be encouraged. Formally educated persons can also to continue their education for either self-development or higher professional advancement in a non-formal way.

6.12. Observations from the Study Areas

West Bengal Issues

Shishu Shiksha Karmasuchi

Demand for education in the state increased **substantially after Total Literacy ?**

Campaign was successfully launched in the State in the early nineties. However, there was inadequacy in terms of number of schools and access to available schools, particularly in remote areas and those habitations where educationally backward classes lived. It was not possible to open primary schools in all such habitations wherever there were some children

not having access to primary schools. Government of West Bengal, therefore, decided to introduce an alternative elementary education system, which could reach any corner of the state, cater to the special needs of the children, less costly, but qualitatively comparable with the formal education system. In 1997-98 the Education Department, Government of West Bengal, took up such a programme and planned to set up about 1000 Child Education Centres, with the help of Panchayati Raj bodies. Subsequently the programme was transferred to the Department of Panchayats and Rural Development (PRDD) of the State. The PRDD took up the programme as Shisu Shiksha Karmasuchi, and decided to set up the Shishu Shiksha Kendras (SSK), wherever there were at least twenty children not having access to any existing primary school or require some special dispensation, which are not available in the formal primary schools. Other essential features of the Karmasuchi are:

- i. Shisu Shiksha Kendras are opened at the initiative of the community and are owned and managed by them.
- ii. Funds are provided by the State Government and Panchayats act as facilitators only.
- iii. It is a demand driven programme; Kendras can be opened in school-less villages / village with schools which have inadequate infrastructures [in terms of space and / or teachers etc.]
- iv. Curriculum and syllabus are as prescribed by the West Bengal Board of Primary Education and same textbooks as prescribed for the formal primary schools are used.
- v. Classroom transactions are on the principles of Joyful Learning'
- vi. Teachers, called Sahayikas are mostly women from the locality

Organisational Structure & Administration of the Karmasuchi

The PRDD assigned the responsibility of implementing the programme to a Mission

created in December 1999 in the name and style of Paschimbanga Rajya Shishu Shiksha Mission (PBRSSM). The task of the Mission are supervision and monitoring of the programme, customization of training of the Sahayikas, Supervisors, members of the Managing Committees of the Shisu Shiksha Kendras (SSK), development of Management Information System, experimentation in the field of community mobilization, experimentation with and development of TLM, generation of demand for education where demand is still low etc. The Mission is to function under the control of the Panchayats and Rural Development Department. In its turn, the PBRSSM is supposed to operate with the help of the Zilla Parishads. At the Zilla Parishad level a cell under the Shiksha-Sanskriti-Tathya-O-Krira Sthayee Samiti of the Zilla Parishad renders necessary help in implementing the programme. At Panchayat Samiti level also there is one cell to assist the Sthayee Samiti of the Panchayat Samiti. Once any community fulfills the conditions and decides to set up a Shishu Shiksha Kendra, it will form a Managing Committee (MC) and apply for approval of the Zilla Parishad (through the Panchayat Samiti) and also for release of fund. The managing committee of the Kendra will appoint the Sahayikas in accordance with the guidelines. Sahayikas are the pivot of the programme and they were mostly housewives with necessary qualifications who were provided intensive residential training, mostly on teaching methodology and class room transactions in phases to teach following principles of joyful learning. For supervision of the academic aspects of the programme Academic Supervisors(AS) at the scale of one Supervisor for every twenty Kendras are engaged by the Zilla Parishads. Initially mostly retired teachers were engaged as Academic Supervisors and were gradually replaced by Sahayikas with experience and having graduate degree. They visit every centre regularly and review with the Sahayikas about progress of teaching and overall performance of the Kendra. The reports submitted by the Academic Supervisors are considered by the concerned Sthayee Samiti of the Panchayat Samiti.

Functioning of the SSKs

Though the programme was launched in 1997-98 but it took off really in the next year at the end of which there were only 1,789 SSKs. The number increased rapidly over the years and as per report compiled through DISE - 2008-09, there are 16,109 SSKs. It would have been impossible to establish such a large number of conventional schools within around ten years and large number of students who would have remained out of schools could be imparted primary education in those SSKs. Total number of students during the year 2008-09 in the SSKs was 14,93,104. Number of students in class IV during the year 2008-09 was 2,69,611. The percentages of learners belonging to SC, ST, OBC and Muslim/Minority during that year were 29.56%, 11.75% and 37.79% respectively. The percentage of OBC learners was 3.03%. Thus the SSKs largely met the demand of the children from the backward sections of the community. Also, 50.29% of the learners of SSKs during the year were girls. The numbers of Sahayikas during the year 2008-09 was 46,370. The people – teacher ratio thus works out to be 32.2 during the year, which was much better than that of the conventional schools and was useful in providing proper attention to the students. The district-wise number of SSKs, number of Sahayikas and learners at the end of the year 2008-09 are given below.

Table- 6.1

District wise No. of SSK/SAHAYIKA & Std. Wise Learners as per DISE 2010-11

District Name	No. of SSKs	No. of Sahayika/ Sahayak	Learners class –I	Learners class –II	Learners class –III	Learners class –IV	Total Learners
Bankura	449	893	8052	5090	4612	4426	22180
Bardhaman	1063	3043	31560	19671	17964	17666	86861
Birbhum	650	1547	15976	11331	10405	10177	47889
Dakshin							
Dinajpur	531	1460	14990	8317	7302	7507	38116

Dghc	541	1137	7013	4418	4027	3496	18954
Haora	306	857	10390	6128	5581	5406	27505
Hugli	277	802	7382	4373	4114	4416	20285
Jalpaiguri	1086	3231	36627	22358	20132	19107	98224
Koch Bihar	698	1849	22042	14305	12854	12358	61559
Maldah	618	2218	28812	20445	18963	17617	85837
Murshidabad	1581	5709	69803	48469	42890	40617	201779
Nadia	555	1477	16652	10614	9987	9742	46995
North 24							
Parganas	955	3074	34697	23225	21426	21141	100489
Paschim							
Medinipur	2458	6442	59814	34645	32460	33103	160022
Purba							
Medinipur	1445	4017	43466	22672	21423	21190	108751
Puruliya	416	793	10080	4651	3790	3164	21685
Siliguri	283	823	9771	6062	5403	5141	26377
24 Pgs.(S)	1213	4020	57155	28994	25472	23722	135343
Uttar							
Dinajpur	975	3261	46040	26615	22404	20770	115829
Total	16100	46653	530322	322383	291209	280766	1424680

Source: atiwb.gov.in/index_htm_files/education.pdf

Madhyamik Shiksha Kendras

West Bengal has substantial gap in access to upper primary education. Many students passing out of primary level were unable to get admission in class V and many of the upper primary classes were over crowded hampering quality of education. In that background it was decided in the year 2003-04 to set up Madhyamik Shiksha Kendras (MSKs) to provide access to upper primary level (class V to class VIII) education in areas not having high schools in the vicinity and 863 MSKs were established in that year itself. Those were also

being managed by the committee predominantly of the guardians under overall supervision of the Panchayats. The number of MSKs gradually shot up to 1900 in the year 2008. The State Government has since decided to open formal upper primary schools in areas having inadequate access to upper primary education and new MSKs were no longer being established. The number of students of MSK, which was just 65,709 during the year 2003-04 increased to 3,83,312 during the year 2008-09 and there were 72,248 learners in class VIII in that year. Many of them would not have continued to study up to that level without the MSKs. Thus those institutions are meeting the demand of upper primary level education in respective areas of the state substantially. Those were mostly established in areas inhabited by people from educationally backward communities as will be evidenced from the fact that the percentages of students of MSKs belonging to SC, ST and Muslim and were 29.97%, 10.32% and 36.86% respectively. The percentage of learners from general social category during the year was 15.76% only and 54.24% of the learners of MSKs during the year were girls. There were 9957 number of teachers, called Samprasarakas in the MSKs. For supervising functioning of the MSKs there are District Quality Managers at the Zilla Parishad and their work is supervised by one/two Assistant Education Coordinators, for which new post were created in the Zilla Parishad. The overall administration of the SSK and MSK is looked after by one Deputy Magistrate, who is called the District Nodal Officer, under supervision of the Secretary of the Zilla Parishad.

Table- 6.2

Madhyamik Shiksha Kendras

District Name	No. of MSKs	Total Learners	No. of Teachers
Bankura	73	13106	395
Bardhaman	99	20591	534
Birbhum	101	19854	513

Dakshin Dinajpur	40	8081	212
Dghc	68	7297	351
Howrah	27	5853	134
Hoogli	27	5295	141
Jalpaiguri	113	28070	551
Cooch Bihar	118	22376	615
Maldah	108	24723	517
Murshidabad	202	46559	1063
Nadia	106	28283	568

Source: atiwb.gov.in/index_html_files/education.pdf

Infrastructure of SSKs and MSKs

The SSKs and MSKs were established with initiatives of the community, who were generally from poorer background and large number of such centers were opened within a short period as mentioned before. In most of the cases those had to start in temporary accommodation with inadequate space and other necessary infrastructure. The community and the Panchayats had to work together to develop required infrastructure and to identify suitable land for development of the same. This has been a serious challenge and though the infrastructure has improved over the years the same is still inadequate in many cases. As per the report of DISE 2008, only 9,620 SSKs had their own building and there were 2,819 SSKs without any building. In 653 SSKs construction of building was in progress and 3,017 SSKs were running in multiple-use buildings. Those apart 4,391 SSKs did not have any drinking water source of their own and 9,081 SSKs had no toilets. The number of SSKs having separate toilet for girls was only 1,749. So far as MSKs are concerned, DISE 2008 data shows that out of 1,900 MSKs, 1,425 MSKs had their own buildings and construction of buildings was in progress in respect of 111 MSKs. Another 327 MSKs were running in

multiple-use building and 37 MSKs had no building. There were no drinking water sources in 370 MSKs and 655 MSKs were without toilets. Only 866 MSKs had separate toilets for girls, which is essential to prevent girls from dropping out of school. Thus, there is need for more investment in developing proper infrastructure of the SSKs and the MSKs.

Quality Interventions and Other Special Initiatives

Ensuring good quality of education in both SSKs and MSKs was one of the priorities from the very beginning. Training of Sahayikas, Samprasaraks, Academic Supervisors etc was a continuous drive towards that end including one diploma course for the Sahayikas in collaboration with Netaji Subhas Open University. There is weekly radio programme, known as “Sahayika’s Asor” to help the Sahayikas to improve their knowledge, skill and motivation. A programme called “Shiksha Deep Prakalpa” was launched. The same is aimed at improvement in teaching learning of Bengali, English, Mathematics, Environmental Science and also special programmes like reading guarantee and writing guarantee and remedial teaching of students are covered under the Prakalpa. During 2008-09 the reading guarantee programme was up-scaled in all the 16,109 SSKs of the state. With a view to assessing the quality of functioning of SSKs a composite **School Efficiency Index (SEI)**, to measure various aspects of functioning of the SSKs has been worked out. The SEI provides the strength and weakness of functioning of the SSKs. The SEI is worked out by the Sahayikas themselves under supervision of the Academic Supervisors and the compiled figures are shared with all concerned for taking measures in improvement of the functioning of the SSKs. The Panchayat Samiti and the Gram Panchayats who are more directly associated with functioning of the SSKs should analyse the SEI of SSKs within their jurisdiction and take appropriate remedial steps for improvement. In respect of MSKs special interventions for improvement of teaching & learning on Science and Language are made.

Making available teaching and learning materials for the SSKs and MSKs are other initiatives in improving quality of learning.

Functioning of the SSK and MSKs and the Panchayats

All the three tiers of Panchayats are responsible for carrying out various responsibilities for proper functioning of the MSKs. One important role of the Panchayats is to develop proper physical infrastructure of those institutions for imparting education as well as to provide all other non-academic inputs. Developing proper campus, plantation of trees, arranging electricity, water supply and toilets are very crucial in this respect. The Panchayats at all levels should also allocate fund to the SSKs & MSKs for meeting their various needs for promoting quality of education. Many Panchayats also arrange scholarship to retain meritorious but poor students from not dropping out. Also, increased supervision on functioning of the centres and extending required support to the SSKs and MSKs help those centres to impart better quality education to the local children.

6.13. Facts and Statistics from the Survey Areas

Table- 6.3

Non Formal Education Institutions of Jalpaiguri District, 2005- 2006

Number of Special and Non-formal Educational Institutions by type in the district of Jalpaiguri

(Number)

Type of Institutions	Year				
	2001-02	2002-03	2003-04	2004-05	2005-06
(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
1 Sishu Siksha Kendras	931	1129	1129	1108	1137
2 Madhyamik Siksha Kendras	..	..	..	..	101
3 Adult High Schools	1	1	1	1	1

4	Centres of Rabindra Mukta Vidyalaya	2	2	3	3	6
5	Sanskrit Tols	1	1	1	1	1
6	Ekalabya Schools	..	1	1	1	1
7	Educational Institutions for the Blind and other Physically & Mentally Handicapped	5	5	5	5	5
8	Non-formal Education Centres	100	100	100	100	-
9	Anganwadi (education) Centres under I.C.D.S.	2564	2568	2643	2564	2564
10	Social Welfare Homes under M.E.E.Deptt.	2	2	2	2	2
11	Reformatory or certified Institutions or Welfare Homes under Social Welfare Deptt.for the Juveniles or destitute children or the children of red-light areas	1	1	1	1	1
12	Jan Shiksha Sansthan	1	1	1	1	1
Total		3608	3811	3887	3787	3820
Source: Jalpaiguri District Statistical Handbook, Bureau of Applied Economics and Statistics. Govt of West Bengal. 2006.						

From the above table it is visible that in the district of Jalpaiguri there are 931 Sishu Siksha Kendras in 2001- 2002, 1129 Kendras in 2002- 2003, 1129 kendras in 2003- 2004, 1108 Kendras in 2004- 2005, 1137 Kendras in 2005- 2006. In the year 2004- 2005 the number of Kendras decreased, whereas the number of Kendras increased in 2005- 2006. There are 101 Madhyamik Siksha Kendras. There is only one Adult High School. Centres of Rabindra Mukta Vidyalaya in 2001- 2002 and 2002- 2003 are 2 and for the years 2003- 2004 and 2004- 2005 are 3. For the year 2005- 2006 the number has

increased to 6. There is a single Sanskrit Tol in the District. There is a single Ekalabya School in the District. There are 5 Educational Institutions for the Blind and other Physically & Mentally Handicapped in the District. Till the year 2004- 2005, there are 100 Non-formal Education Centres. There are 2564 Anganwadi (education) Centres under I.C.D.S. There are 2 Social Welfare Homes under M.E.E.Deptt. There is a single Reformatory or certified Institutions or Welfare Homes under Social Welfare Deptt.for the Juveniles or destitute children or the children of red-light areas and a Jan Shiksha Sansthan.

There are two non formal education centers, a Madhya Shiksha Kendra near Chauhaddi mouza and a Shishu Shiksha Kendra at the mouza.

Situation of Madhya Shiksha Kendra (MSK) near Chauhaddi mouza

Table- 6.4

Number of Students enrolled in Madhya Shiksha Kendra near Chauhaddi Mouza

Class	General		Scheduled Caste		Scheduled Tribe		Other Backward Class		Minority		Total	
	Male	Female	Male	Female	Male	Female	Male	Female	Male	Female	Male	Female
V	2	4	55	37	0	1	0	2	12	15	69	59
VI	0	1	47	29	0	2	0	1	7	11	54	44
VII	3	2	27	36	4	0	0	0	15	17	49	59
VIII	1	3	33	26	0	0	0	0	7	14	41	43
Source: Field Survey, 2010- 2011.												

From the above table it is found that the number of Scheduled Caste students enrolled in every class is highest. Here in Chauhaddi mouza most of the Scheduled Castes are Rajbanshis. Then at the second position are the minorities, the Muslim students. At the third position are the number of General students, at the fourth position are the Scheduled Tribe students and there are least number of Other Backward Class students.

Table- 6.5

Number of Students enrolled in Shishu Shiksha Kendra in Chauhaddi Mouza

Class	General		Scheduled Caste		Scheduled Tribe		Other Backward Class		Minority		Total	
	Male	Female	Male	Female	Male	Female	Male	Female	Male	Female	Male	Female
I	4	5	15	13	1	2	1	0	4	3	25	23
II	0	1	11	10	1	2	0	1	5	4	17	18
III	2	2	10	12	4	5	0	0	8	6	24	25
IV	2	1	12	11	1	1	1	0	6	5	22	18
Source: Field Survey, 2010- 2011.												

From the above table it is found that the number of Scheduled Caste students' enrolled in every class is highest. Then at the second position are the minorities, the Muslim students. At the third position are the number of Scheduled Tribe students, at the fourth position are the General students and there are least number of Other Backward Classes students.

Situation of Shishu Shiksha Kendra in Gartali Jalpesh mouza

In Gartali Jalpesh mouza there is a Shishu Shiksha Kendra.

Table- 6.6

Number of Students enrolled in Shishu Shiksha Kendra in Gartali Jalpesh Mouza

Class	General		Scheduled Caste		Other Backward Class		Minority		Total	
	Male	Female	Male	Female	Male	Female	Male	Female	Male	Female
I	3	2	17	14	0	0	1	1	21	17
II	1	1	12	11	0	1	0	0	13	14
III	3	2	15	14	0	0	0	0	18	16
IV	7	6	10	9	0	0	1	1	18	16
Total	10	9	58	54	0	1	2	2	70	65
Source: Field Survey, 2010- 2011										

From the above table it is found that the number of Scheduled Caste students enrolled in every class is highest. Then at the second position are the General students. At the third position are the Minorities, the Muslim students. At the fourth position are the Other Backward Classes students. There is least number of Other Backward Classes students.

6.14. General Observation

In both the mouzas, it is prominent that the attendance of the students from the Rajbanshi Community is highest in both the Shishu Shiksha Kendras and Madhya Shiksha Kendra. It is because of the huge Rajbanshi concentration in the mouzas. But it is to be noted that due to lack of primary schools and distance of the schools from their residence the children of both the mouzas get enrolled at the Shishu Shiksha Kendras. In each mouza there is only a single primary school. And also it is obvious that due to lack

of favourable ambience many children become dropouts or school left outs, who again get enrolled in these Kendras.

At the Madhya Shiksha Kendras, the situation is very similar. Lack of sufficient secondary schools results in the huge enrolment of students at Kendras. Many of them are dropouts from the formal schooling because of various reasons. The reasons are mostly economic and there is general lack of interest on the students' part, and which is also true in case of their family. Most of the students are first generation learners in case of Chauhaddi mouza.

6.15. Conclusion

It is true that the non- formal education centers have contributed a lot in regards to the school dropout children. In both of the study areas, these centers play great roles in educating children from the families belonging to below poverty lines (BPL). Non- Formal Education means learning to change one's behavior to enhance the quality of life through work and values without formal schooling. The academic objectives of NFE are clustered around dropouts from formal education, functional illiterates, unemployed or underemployed youth and adults. NFE is not a counter activity in opposition to formal education, but complement the formal stream of education, NFE has the potential of being a life-long education.

Some of the students, who are enrolled at the non- formal education centers of the study area, are school dropouts, but a huge portion is enrolled in these schools because they are close to their homes. These non- formal education centers fulfil the scarcity of schools in the areas. These institutions offer all the facilities similar to those provided at the formal education centers. But still the number of school dropouts at the study areas is

huge and is a fact to be worried about. Last but not least, the actuality which needs to be mentioned is that the national and international policies and programmes are quite adequate in paper and not in field. Goals are far away to achieve as the implementation processes are inadequate and meager. A general lack of interest on the part of the persons/ related institutions supposed to implement the programmes at the grass root levels and simultaneously common lack of awareness among the mass to avail the benefits of these programmes are important factors.